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MASTER'S FINAL PROJECT

STRATEGIC MANAGEMENT

OF PROJECTS AND BUSINESS



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STRATEGIC PROJECT AND BUSINESS MANAGEMENT

INTRODUCTION

Strategic Project and Business Management has become a key element in ensuring the competitiveness and sustainability of organisations in an economic environment characterised by uncertainty, globalisation and constant change. Companies can no longer limit themselves to managing their operations from a purely operational perspective; they must integrate business strategy with effective project management as a driver of transformation and growth.

ABSTRACT

This master's final project analyses the importance of strategic project management as a key tool for business decision-making. By studying agile methodologies such as Scrum and Kanban, it explores their practical application to a business diversification process.

The work combines a theoretical approach with a practical case study to analyse how agile project management contributes to assessing the economic, operational and social viability of a new business model. It also examines the benefits of adopting advanced techniques in terms of efficiency, innovation and customer focus.

STRATEGIC PROJECT AND BUSINESS MANAGEMENT

Strategic project management focuses on aligning projects with the company's mission, vision and strategic objectives. It is not simply about executing projects efficiently, but about selecting, prioritising and managing projects that truly create value for the organisation. From this perspective, projects become key instruments for innovation, diversification and continuous improvement.

One of the most relevant aspects of strategic management is analysis of the internal and external environment. This analysis identifies opportunities, threats, strengths and weaknesses, facilitating informed strategic decisions. Based on this diagnosis, the company can define clear objectives and design action plans consistent with its positioning and capabilities.

Strategic planning connects directly with project management by translating business objectives into concrete initiatives. Project prioritisation, the definition of key performance indicators and efficient resource allocation are essential to ensure consistency between strategy and execution.

This topic was chosen out of an interest in understanding how proper alignment between business strategy and project management can facilitate entry into new markets, reduce risks and generate sustainable value at both economic and social levels.

BENEFITS AND APPLICATION OF AGILE METHODOLOGIES IN STRATEGIC MANAGEMENT

First, they allow better risk management, as projects develop through short phases that facilitate early detection of deviations and the adoption of corrective measures.

Second, agile methodologies encourage efficient use of resources by prioritising activities that generate the most value for the organisation and the customer. This is particularly relevant to diversification projects, where initial investment must be carefully managed.

Agile methodologies also promote an organisational culture based on collaboration, transparency and continuous improvement. Teams acquire greater autonomy and responsibility, increasing their involvement and commitment to the company's strategic objectives.

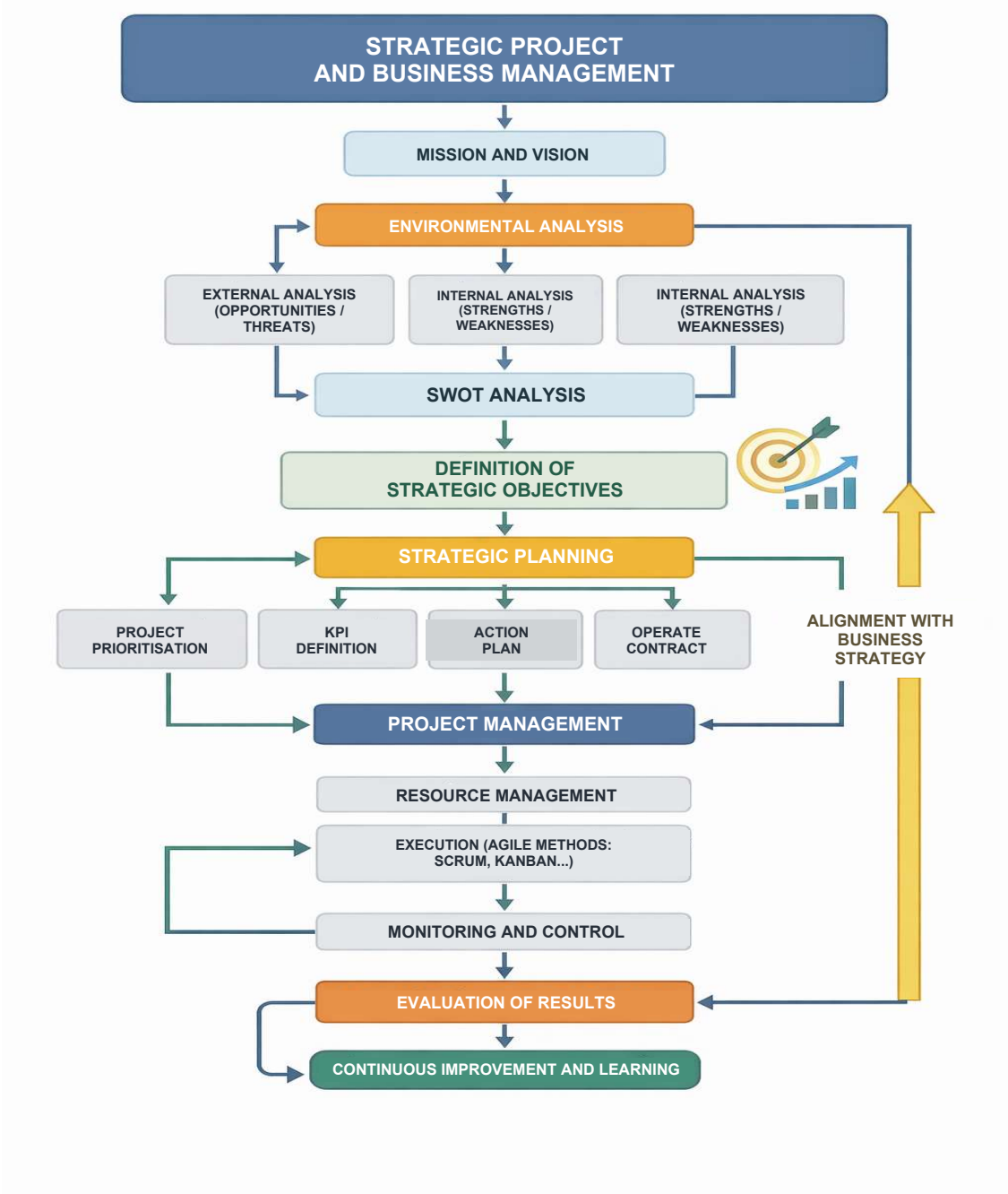
SCRUM AND AGILE METHODOLOGIES IN STRATEGIC MANAGEMENT

Scrum, as an agile methodology, is based on incremental value delivery and constant collaboration between project participants. Its defined structure, with clear roles and regular events, facilitates strategic project control and continuous evaluation of results.

Kanban, in turn, focuses on managing workflow and continuously improving processes. From a strategic management perspective, Kanban identifies bottlenecks, optimises resources and ensures greater operational stability.

Both methodologies, integrated into strategic project management, improve the organisation's ability to adapt to change and respond effectively to the demands of its environment.

STRATEGIC PROJECT AND BUSINESS MANAGEMENT FLOWCHART.



PROGRAMME AND PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Programme and project management provides the methodological framework needed to plan, execute, control and close projects in a structured way. A project is defined as a temporary effort aimed at creating a unique product, service or result, while a programme groups related projects to maximise overall benefits.

Project management follows a lifecycle consisting of initiation, planning, execution, monitoring and control, and closure. Each phase fulfils a specific function and contributes to overall project success. Initiation defines scope, identifies stakeholders and justifies the project strategically and economically. Planning establishes the schedule, budget, resources and risks. Execution implements the plan, while monitoring and control assess performance and enable corrective action. Finally, closure consolidates results and records lessons learned.

Effective resource management, stakeholder communication and risk management are critical throughout the project lifecycle. The project manager's leadership also plays a key role, coordinating the team, resolving conflicts and ensuring alignment with strategic objectives.

THE IMPORTANCE OF INTRODUCING AGILE METHODOLOGIES INTO PROGRAMME AND PROJECT MANAGEMENT

Agile methodologies emerge as an effective response to traditional management models, offering flexibility, continuous adaptation and a clear customer focus.

The importance of Strategic Project and Business Management lies in its ability to connect an organisation's strategic objectives with practical execution. In an increasingly complex business environment, projects become the main vehicle for implementing corporate strategy. Every innovation, expansion or organisational improvement initiative is essentially structured as a project that must be managed efficiently.

Traditionally, many organisations have approached project management from a rigid perspective, based on extensive initial planning with limited ability to adapt to change. However, this approach is restrictive where requirements evolve, markets are dynamic and customer expectations change rapidly.

Agile methodologies represent a paradigm shift in strategic project management. Their iterative and incremental approach allows companies to learn continuously, validate strategic hypotheses and adjust decisions based on actual results. From a strategic management perspective, this is a significant competitive advantage: it facilitates decisions based on current information and reduces the uncertainty associated with complex projects. Agile methodologies also promote greater alignment between business strategy and market needs. By placing the customer at the centre of the process, organisations can design more appropriate value propositions, improve the customer experience and strengthen their competitive positioning.

In conclusion, I would say that strategic project management and programme and project management are complementary disciplines essential to business success. Proper integration allows organisations to translate strategy into tangible results, manage complexity and generate sustainable long-term value. Agile methodologies reinforce this capability, providing flexibility, continuous learning and a clear customer focus.

APPLICATION OF ADVANCED TECHNIQUES

Applying advanced techniques such as data analysis, machine learning and artificial intelligence further increases project potential.

These tools enable outcome prediction, anomaly detection and task automation, leading to more efficient and effective project management. By analysing large historical and real-time datasets, organisations can identify and mitigate potential risks before they become significant problems. However, making full use of these techniques in projects is not straightforward: it requires analytical expertise, cutting-edge technology and a deep understanding of the specific project domain. It is also essential to address data privacy and security to ensure regulatory compliance and protect the confidentiality of sensitive information.

Integrating advanced techniques into projects covers several key areas and aspects. For example, during planning, historical data analysis and predictive modelling can improve estimates of required resources, delivery times and potential obstacles. This allows project teams to set realistic expectations and develop risk mitigation strategies from the outset, facilitating real-time monitoring of progress and performance. Data-driven dashboards and early-warning systems allow

project managers to proactively identify deviations or potential problems and take timely corrective action to prevent delays or failures to meet commitments.

Data analysis in projects can significantly improve decision-making. By providing evidence-based information and statistical analysis, these techniques help project leaders evaluate options and the potential impact of each decision. This promotes greater transparency and better-informed, data-driven decisions, reducing the likelihood of costly errors. Data-driven project management platforms and tools allow efficient information sharing, activity coordination and real-time updates to all parties on progress and changes.

Advanced techniques offer opportunities for continuous improvement and innovation in project management. By analysing results and lessons learned from previous projects, organisations can identify improvement areas and develop best practices. Using new technologies and analytical approaches, such as the Internet of Things (IoT) or social-media sentiment analysis, organisations can also discover new ways to optimise processes and maximise the value delivered by projects.

ANALYSIS OF A PRACTICAL CASE

The case concerns the Operations Director of a company specialising in healthcare equipment distribution, with an established track record and a strong position in its sector. Facing growing competition and the need to ensure long-term business sustainability, the organisation decides to expand its business model into hospitality and leisure. Its key objectives are to diversify revenue, use existing synergies in technical knowledge and supply chains, and adapt to new opportunities linked to wellbeing, health and customer experience in leisure and hospitality settings.

Strategic analysis and project viability from a strategic management perspective, and entry into a new sector, involve multiple challenges. These include understanding the particular characteristics of hospitality and leisure, adapting the existing value proposition and ensuring the new business model is viable, scalable and sustainable over time.

To address these challenges, a comprehensive analysis examines the factors determining project viability. It considers traditional economic variables such as profitability, return on investment (ROI) and operating costs, as well as

social and community factors such as the impact on users' health, environmental sustainability and the creation of real value for end customers.

In this context, advanced data analysis techniques play a key role. By studying historical sales data, sector trends, customer behaviour and market analysis, the company can identify consumption patterns, segment potential customers and anticipate demand in the new sector.

Agile methodologies and technological support make project management a fundamental strategic element. Scrum is particularly suitable for the uncertain initial project stages. Through short, iterative sprints, the company can develop product and service prototypes, validate business hypotheses and obtain early market feedback. Machine learning allows customer feedback analysis, emerging-trend detection and dynamic adjustment of the value proposition. Predictive models can assess acceptance of new products, optimise prices or forecast risks before they harm the project. Kanban is especially useful later, as the new model becomes stably integrated into the company's main activity. Its focus on workflow visualisation, limiting work in progress and continuous improvement helps optimise processes, shorten delivery times and increase operational efficiency.

In this more mature environment, artificial intelligence can automate processes, optimise inventories, improve production planning and support operational decision-making through recommendation systems and real-time analysis.

Case study conclusion

Combining Scrum and Kanban with advanced data analysis, machine learning and artificial intelligence allows the company to manage diversification flexibly, adaptively and based on objective information. This methodological and technological integration aligns operational execution with strategic objectives, reduces uncertainty when entering new markets and strengthens sustainable innovation.

FINAL CONCLUSIONS

Strategic Project and Business Management is a fundamental pillar of organisational success in complex, changing environments. Adopting agile methodologies such as Scrum and Kanban allows companies to manage strategic projects more effectively, reduce risks and encourage innovation. The case study shows that choosing and applying agile methodologies appropriately can facilitate diversification and help create sustainable, competitive, customer-focused business models. Advanced techniques also lead to more efficient and effective project management.

FINAL REFLECTION

From a personal perspective, studying strategic project management alongside programme and project management shows that real value lies not only in executing projects correctly, but in choosing the right projects. Alignment between strategy, people and methodologies becomes the differentiating factor allowing organisations to adapt, innovate and grow sustainably in a constantly evolving business environment. Together with agile methodologies and advanced techniques, this highlights the importance of a flexible approach focused on continuous learning. Experience shows that strategy should not be understood as a rigid, unchanging plan, but as a dynamic process evolving as the organisation interacts with its environment.

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